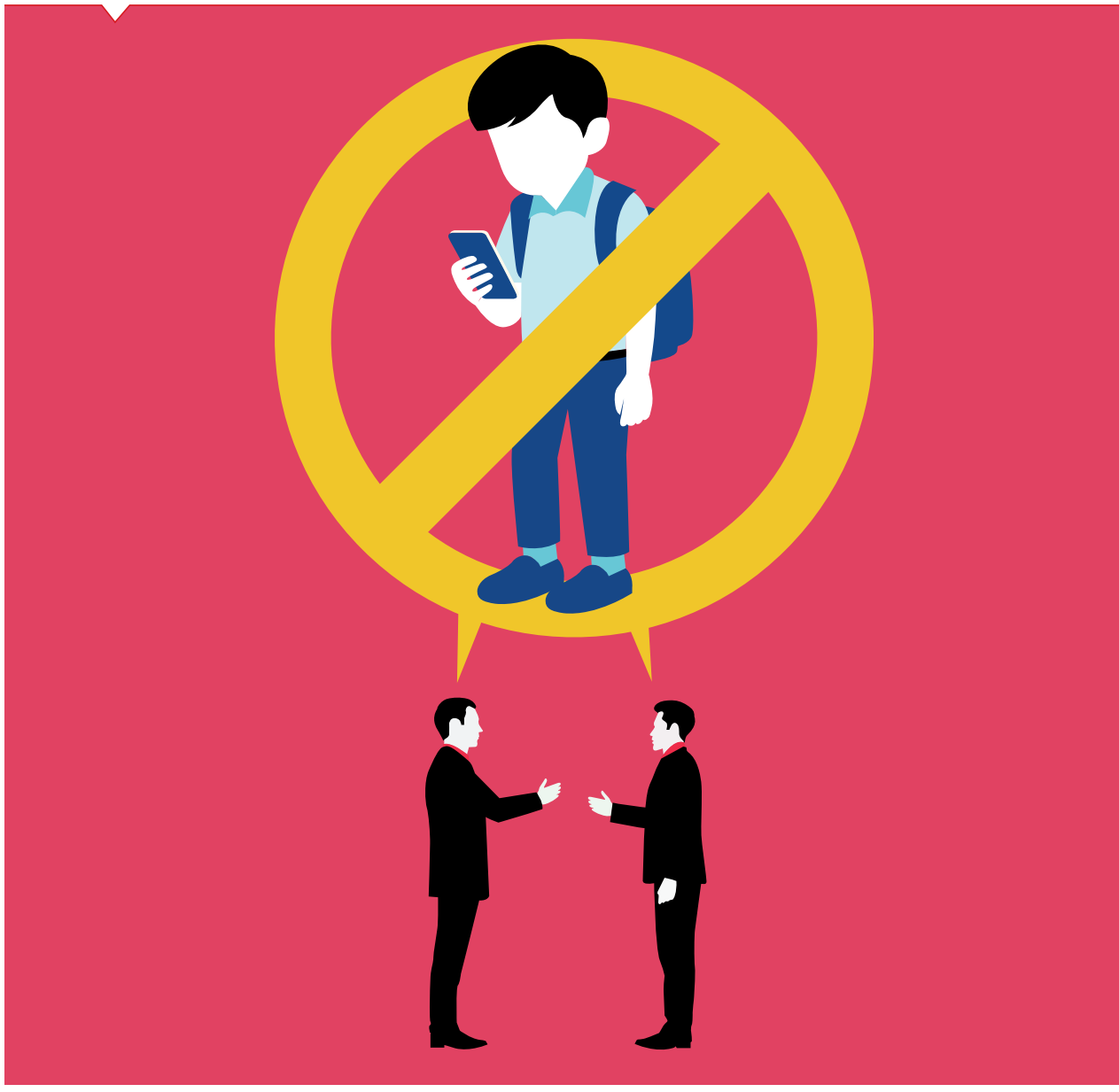

▶ KARNATAKA

No Log In Till You Are 16

Siddaramaiah, Chandrababu take the first step in protecting children from unregulated social media. The question may go viral

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

INDIA NOW HAS A BILLION INTERNET USERS. IT'S A DATA POINT touted with pride. But now, two of its most IT-savvy states are moving to down the blinds on one troubling aspect: social media usage among children, often hypothesised to have adverse effects on cognition. The near-identical announcements by Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh came on the same day, March 6, differing only by a small degree. Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah proposed a ban on social media for children under 16 in the 2026-27 state budget; his counterpart, N. Chandrababu Naidu, told his state assembly that a plan to restrict social media access to under-13s would be rolled out in 90 days.

India's internet user base is the second highest globally, after China. Seen through the lens of technology adoption, it's a milestone ordinarily taken to

Illustration by **RAJ VERMA**